

10 Reforms That Can Save Tigers

1 Tigers need inviolate space with no human interference. Also, there is a need for connectivity between forests; their fragmentation is a serious impediment to long-term tiger conservation.

2 Intelligence-led enforcement or, in other words, proactive approach is required to curb organised trade in tiger parts.

3 There is no effective deterrence as prosecution in wildlife cases is dismal and even if arrested, procuring bail for poachers is relatively easy. Law needs to be amended.

4 The flourishing market of tiger parts has to be curtailed by putting

forest departments functioning mostly in an ad-hoc and opaque manner. Roles and responsibilities need to be defined.

6 Greater use of technology like genetic profiling of the entire tiger population in the tiger reserves and use of field-tracking device like GPS for better management of forests is required, besides forensic methods to prosecute poachers.

7 Creation of specialised cadre for each aspect of forest management, namely enforcement, administration, wildlife, relations with local communities and forest management.

8 Involvement of private parties like academicians, experts and wildlife enthusiasts in the management of forests.

9 Moratorium on civil construction inside the forests. In the last decade, over 70 per cent of funds have been spent on civil construction inside the tiger reserves.

10 Involvement of the local communities in sustainable use, management and conservation of forests.

greater pressure and persuasion on China with the help of international bodies like CITES and EIA.

5 There is no accountability mechanism in place with the

believed to be involved in most of the tiger killings in Panna and Rajasthan. Tracing the poachers, we visit Khiraini on the road that leads to the Bandhavgarh Tiger Reserve. We meet Dauwa who spills the beans. Dabuliya's outburst is part of a turf war between poachers on who will get access to prime hunting grounds in Karnataka and Maharashtra.

The stakes are high enough: 30 tiger skins for each gang, each year, which means 30 tigers dead and crores earned. That makes them extremely competitive. "Till about two

with Qureshi in 2007.

Three hours away is Panna National Park which lost all its tigers, 35 in just five years, to poaching while the Forest Department blatantly lied that all was well (*see box*). Now they have started a novel initiative to provide the Pardhis with alternative means of livelihood, other than hunting. In 2007, with the help of World Wide Fund for Nature-India, the forest department opened residential schools for the children of the Pardhis. "It was very difficult to convince Pardhis to send their children to school. They

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DABULIYA BAI, HEAD OF A PARDHI CLAN, IS BELIEVED TO HAVE DELIVERED SOME 35 TIGER SKINS TO SANSAR CHAND

years ago, the two gangs would agree to travel to different locations to poach, but now they all want to go to Karnataka and Maharashtra where there is a healthy tiger population," says Nitin Desai, WPS's director in central India, who has been instrumental in the successful investigation of poaching cases in Gujarat and Madhya Pradesh. "There is also a rift in revenue sharing as they are fighting for a larger share of the booty," explains Manjula Shrivastava, an anti-poaching lawyer in Katni with a record of 98 per cent conviction in poaching cases. Dauwa claims that he has nothing to do with poaching but he fails to mention that his wife, Sukh Chiana, was arrested

thought it was another ploy to arrest them by the Forest Department," says Indrabhan Singh Bundela, field officer for the Pardhi project here. The children, in all about 200, some of them sons and daughters of the most notorious poachers, talk freely about how their parents used to kill tigers and bring trophies home. Some Pardhi families, all of whom were poachers earlier, have been hired as local guardians by the school. One of them is Daheli Pardhi, who says that he was involved in tiger and leopard poaching in the past as there was no other source of livelihood. "Now my people do not trust me. They think I have changed loyalties," he says. That is why he does not get to know where his